

ZERO BUDGET, VERSION 2 — THE MACHINE IS NOW BUILT

Getting Picacho in front of people

Step-by-step distribution for one founder with a working product, no ad budget, and no audience yet. Version 1 (Aug 10) told you what to build before you could sell; as of tonight, nearly all of it exists. This version tells you what to do with it — in order.

What changed since v1

A free generation **every day** (v1 begged for a one-time free tier — you shipped something stickier). A **\$9 entry plan** (v1's outreach had to sell €19 cold). A public **gallery** of scored renders and two **comparison pages** for the search engines. An **email system** you control from admin. The **agency/rep machinery** v1 imagined — promo codes that track revenue and commission per partner — is already wired into Stripe. Four languages. And every render now carries a verifiable identity score: you no longer market promises, you publish proof.

The two advantages (unchanged, still the whole strategy)

1. **Your product manufactures its own marketing material.** Unlimited professional video and images of a consistent character — exactly what your buyers want and can't make. Publish the output; let it sell the tool.
2. **The brand & compliance rulebook.** Nobody else selling AI video has one. It is the reason a clinic picks you over buying Kling directly. *Honesty check before you pitch it:* platform-wide enforcement is currently switched off behind a feature flag — flip it on (Admin → Feature flags) before the first clinic demo, or pitch it as “rules you define today, enforced on every output.” Never claim what the flag has paused.

Phase 0 — Arm the machine (this week, ~half a day of clicks)

Most of v1's Phase 0 got built for you. What remains is operator work, not engineering.

#	Step	Status / what to do
1	Free tier a stranger can try	DONE — one free generation a day, no card. Better than v1 asked for: it creates a reason to come back tomorrow.
2	Entry price cold outreach can close	DONE — Basic at \$9/mo (12 credits). Your outreach message can now end in a number nobody needs to think twice about.
3	Hang the proof wall	TODO, ~30 min — feature 15–20 of your best renders from your admin page so /gallery is full before anyone lands on it. It is your portfolio, updated by clicking a button.
4	Send the announcement	TODO, ~10 min — the basic-tier-launch email to every free signup: “a free generation every day, plans from \$9.” It is drafted; test it on yourself, then send.
5	One sentence, everywhere, unchanged	DONE on the site (“The same face, in every single frame.”) — now use it verbatim in every bio, caption, and outreach message. If you describe it differently each time, nobody repeats it for you.
6	Claim the handles	TODO, 20 min — same name on TikTok, Instagram, YouTube, X, LinkedIn. Free, and impossible to undo later.
7	Generate the content bank	TODO, one afternoon — one character, 20 scenarios (clinic, café, gym, street, product-in-hand), portrait 9:16 on the new default model. This feeds Phase 2's daily posting for three weeks.

#	Step	Status / what to do
8	Decide the watermark	BUILD ITEM (ask Claude, ~1 session) — free-tier output stamped “Made with Picacho”. v1 was right: it turns every free user into distribution, and removing it becomes a reason to pay.

Phase 1 — Your first 10 paying customers (weeks 1–4)

Unchanged from v1, because it was right and you haven't done it yet: not content, not SEO — direct, personal outreach. It is the only channel that works at zero followers, and the only one that teaches you why people say no. Your background *is* the niche: aesthetic clinics, med spas, salons.

Step 1 — the move that makes it work

Send the work before you ask for anything. Pick a med spa. Look at their Instagram. Generate a 5-second portrait video in their style — consistent presenter, their actual services. Send it with no pitch. One credit, four minutes. Almost nobody in their inbox has ever done this.

Step 2 — the message (keep it this short)

“Hi [name] — I made this for your clinic, no charge, just wanted to show you something. [video] It's the same presenter every time, so you can post daily without hiring anyone. Want me to make three more?”

No link. No pricing. No “quick call?”. The reply you want is “yes” or “how?”. When they ask how: the answer now ends at “from \$9 a month, and you can try it free every day” — two objections v1's version of you couldn't remove.

Step 3 — the daily routine

- 10 outreaches a day, 5 days a week — 200 in a month; at 5% that's your first 10 customers.
- Find them on Instagram and Google Maps: “med spa [city]”, “beauty salon [city]”. Pick the ones posting inconsistently — they already know they have the problem.
- Rotate cities; you're learning which market responds. You speak the language of four of them — Spain and Latin America see the app in Spanish, Italy in Italian, Brazil in Portuguese. Your English-only competitors cannot follow you there.
- Track every send in a sheet: business, city, date, replied, why not. The “why not” column is worth more than the sales.
- Follow up once, seven days later, one line. Never twice.

Expect this to feel slow and uncomfortable. It is still the single highest-value thing you can do, and still the part everyone abandons in week three to build another feature. The product is not what's missing.

Phase 2 — Channels that compound (weeks 3–12, overlapping)

A. Publish the output, daily

One generated video a day to TikTok, Reels, and Shorts — same clip, three platforms, two minutes. The bank from Phase 0 covers your first three weeks. Two formats beat everything: the same character in ten wildly different scenes cut fast (it demonstrates the thing people don't believe), and a screen recording of one typed sentence becoming a finished video. Caption with the sentence from Phase 0. Point profiles at the homepage — the try-it widget lets a curious visitor run your pipeline themselves. Don't chase virality; 90 consecutive days beats one clever idea.

B. Write the pages people search for (one a week)

Write	Because someone types it
DONE: Picacho vs HeyGen · Picacho vs Hedra	Comparison shoppers convert at the highest rate of any organic visitor. Live today, linked in the footer.
“Why AI video really costs 3–4× the sticker price”	The retry tax is the market’s loudest complaint (it shows up in every Reddit thread about pricing) — and “failed renders don’t use your credits” is your answer to it.
Social media content ideas for med spas	They’re out of ideas, not out of tools.
Advertising rules for aesthetic clinics	Your rulebook is literally this answer. No competitor can write the page honestly.
How to keep the same AI face in every video	Your core feature, phrased as the searcher’s problem.
Alternative-to pages (Higgsfield, OpenArt, Kling app)	Same playbook as the two live compare pages; add one per week from the research already done.
Every page ends with the free daily generation, not a sales pitch.	

C. Be useful in rooms where buyers already gather

Facebook groups for med spa / salon owners and aesthetic practitioners; Reddit’s r/smallbusiness, r/Entrepreneur, r/socialmedia, r/marketing — plus the AI-video rooms where the retry-tax complaints live. Answer questions for four weeks before ever mentioning Picacho. Post results, not links; when someone asks “what did you use?”, that question is worth more than any link you could drop.

D. One coordinated launch day (once the drip email is sent and the gallery is full)

Product Hunt, with assets you now actually have: the gallery as proof, the try-it widget as the demo, “a free generation every day” as the hook, \$9 as the price. Prepare: 5 gallery pieces pinned, the two-clip hero reel as the header media, founder comment written in advance, and a launch-day service window where you answer every comment for 12 hours. A good launch is a spike, not a strategy — aim it at the week your daily posting is already running so the spike lands on a moving flywheel.

Phase 3 — Loops that grow without you (month 3+)

Loop	How it works	Status
Agencies as resellers	One agency serving 20 clinics is 20 customers you never had to find. Give each partner a promo code; Stripe applies the discount, Picacho records every sale, the revenue it brought, and the commission owed — per partner, automatically.	PLUMBING BUILT — recruit 5 partners; performance-only cost
Watermark	Free-tier output carries “Made with Picacho”; every post by a free user reaches an audience of people who make content. Paid removes it.	Build item (Phase 0, step 8)
Referral credits	20 credits to the referrer when a referral subscribes; 20 to the newcomer. Credits, not cash — the top-up plumbing already exists.	Build item, ~1 session
Public character gallery	Let people publish a character others can clone; each shared character is a landing page you didn’t write. The /gallery foundation and the consent question are the two prerequisites.	Later — deliberate consent design first

Loop	How it works	Status
App stores	The iOS/Android shells exist; store search is a distribution channel your web-only competitors don't have.	When native polish justifies review

What to measure — four numbers, every Friday, never a fifth

Number	Why this one	Month-1 target
Outreaches sent	The only input you fully control. If this is zero, nothing else matters.	200
Replies	Tests your message, separately from your product.	20
Free signups	Tests whether the promise is interesting. The daily drip now also gives you a second read: how many come back tomorrow.	40
Paying customers	Tests whether the product is worth money. At \$9 the bar to say yes has never been lower.	10

If replies are low, the message is wrong. If replies are fine but signups are low, the landing page is wrong. If signups are fine but nobody pays, the product or price is wrong. Each number tells you which thing to fix — that is the entire reason to track them separately. (Admin → Billing and the user list give you signups, activation, and revenue without a spreadsheet.)

The honest part

This plan asks for roughly two hours a day, most of it unglamorous, for about ninety days before it compounds. There is no zero-cost tactic that skips that; anyone selling you one is selling you something. The failure mode has not changed since v1: abandoning the routine in week three to build another feature, because building feels like progress and being ignored doesn't. After today, that excuse is gone in a way it wasn't on August 10 — the product is redesigned, repriced, audited, and publishing its own proof. The product is not what's missing. The 200 messages are.

Start tomorrow morning

1. **Feature 15 renders** so the gallery is full. 2. **Send the email** to your free users. 3. **Claim the handles**. 4. **Generate the 20-asset content bank**. 5. **Send the first 10 outreaches** — the work attached, no pitch.